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EDITORIAL



Cultural policy and cultural democracy: a global dialogue

Toward the end of November 2023, a group of researchers, scholars, and other cultural agents from various parts of the world gathered in Santiago, Chile, to discuss the current and future challenges of cultural policy research. The international conference “Cultural Policy and Cultural Democracy: A Global Dialogue” enabled a North–South conversation that brought together a diversity of voices to debate cultural policy at different scales and from multiple perspectives. The central concept that convened us on that occasion is not a new paradigm, yet it has gained renewed prominence in public debate in recent years: cultural democracy.

The conversations and formal papers presented at that first Global Dialogue conference have culminated in this double special issue. Like the conference itself, this special issue is testament to the many rich and nuanced insights that emerge when cultural scholars and practitioners from the Global North are brought into dialogue with their peers in the Global South. This dialogue gives rise to both synergies and tensions; and at its deepest, it raises some productive questions about the evolving practices and disciplines related to cultural management and cultural policy – disciplines that, as Norma Muñoz Del Campo observes in this issue, appear far more distinct and discreet from one another in the Global North.

The authors included in this special issue reflect and analyse a broad range of countries including Central and Latin America, and Eastern and Western Europe. They cover a heterogeneous range of topics from museums as catalysts for democratic revolution to cultural diversity and cultural policy development. The thread that indelibly links these papers together is their particular focus on cultural democracy, and as editors, we hope that this special issue will encourage you as readers to rethink or even reconceptualize your existing notions of cultural democracy, or at the very least, appreciate the concept from a carefully curated set of fresh global contexts and perspectives.

Rather than constituting a coherent set of normative guidelines for state action in the cultural field, cultural democracy can be conceived as a broad horizon of principles and practices, in constant reformation, which has taken shape over time and across different levels of cultural activity. However, from its early formulations to the present day, the challenges of cultural democracy remain open across multiple geographies. On the one hand, we can identify transversal tensions across global cultural systems – such as the need to redistribute symbolic power, to ensure equitable access to cultural goods and services, or to recognize diversity as a democratic foundation. On the other, there also persist localized forms of cultural democracy, which respond to the historical, institutional, and social particularities of each region, producing genealogies that are not always linear or equivalent. This diversity of trajectories reveals that cultural democracy cannot be understood as a homogeneous paradigm but rather as a field in permanent dispute, where local problematics are in dialogue with global questions.

In this introduction, we outline some general conceptual guidelines concerning the notion of cultural democracy, exploring the key points of tension that shape its contemporary agenda – both in its metropolitan developments and in its re-readings from the Global South and Latin America.

Global transformations and cultural policies

To understand the origins of the concept of cultural democracy, it is necessary to identify two long-term processes that, since the mid-twentieth century, have reconfigured the ways in which culture is conceived, managed, and experienced (Pinochet Cobos, 2024). On the one hand, the redistribution of cultural power has displaced the traditional centres of definition and legitimation of the modern subject. Positions that were once authorized to speak on behalf of the universal are today challenged from dimensions that had previously remained subordinated or invisible – gender and sexuality, class, ethnicity, or racialization, among others. In response, discourses have emerged that demand recognition for this long-excluded diversity, shaping new forms of articulation in the contemporary international arena (Aroch, 2015). Thus, we are witnessing a discursive opening that reflects an epochal shift, marked by the irruption of voices that unsettle established hierarchies – from below, from outside, from the margins toward the centres.

On the other hand, we observe a growing acceptance of the anthropological notion of ‘culture’. Without delving into the long and complex trajectory of the concept (Elias, 2000), it is worth emphasizing that the hegemonic use of the definition which associates culture with the corpus of enlightened knowledge deemed worthy of universal preservation and dissemination, is currently tempered by the popularization of the definition of culture which understands it as the ensemble of practices and symbols that shape a collective’s identity. The tension between these conceptual traditions has been reformulated in recent debate in terms of two registers: the *aesthetic register* and the *anthropological register* (Yúdice & Miller, 2002). The first encompasses those repertoires of exceptional value accumulated by Western civilization, closely linked to the fine arts and the legacy of high culture. The second conceives culture as the web of practices, beliefs, and ways of life that give meaning to human collectives, in line with the definition developed by anthropology throughout the twentieth century. These conceptions not only respond to different epistemological logics but also entail divergent principles of action, which often come into friction within the field of contemporary cultural policy.

Globally, these two conceptual orientations have had distinct impacts on the ways in which cultural policies are designed and implemented. The aesthetic approach rests on the assumption that there exist cultural goods of high symbolic value that must be preserved and disseminated – as universal heritage – among those who have been historically excluded from access to them. Cultural democratization policies are thus founded on a logic of diffusion: a limited repertoire of productions stemming from the realm of high culture must be shared with broader and more diverse audiences (Hadley 2021).

In contrast, the anthropological perspective broadens the understanding of culture, encompassing not only artistic expressions but also the ways of life, beliefs, and practices characteristic of different human groups. From this relativist standpoint, cultural policy seeks to acknowledge, support and make visible local diversity. Cultural democracy policies are situated precisely within this second framework, aiming to facilitate and legitimize the plurality of voices and manifestations.

Cultural democracy: the local and the global

The earliest formulations of the cultural democracy paradigm from the Global Centre (Kelly, 1984) sought to directly challenge the cultural authority that monopolizes the definition of the artistic value of a work or cultural product (Hadley & Belfiore, 2018). According to Kelly, the established cultural hierarchy – which elevates the taste of certain social sectors to the

status of a “civilized” or naturally superior taste – cannot be explained solely by class origin or the lack of social mobility. Rather, he argues that there are multiple trajectories leading to adherence to that seemingly unassailable system of values. Hence, as Hadley and Belfiore (2018) recall, the challenge does not simply lie in extending the status of “art” to practices that have been historically excluded, but in questioning and entirely replacing the scale of values upon which that regime of legitimation rests.

In this context, cultural policy acquires a radical and transformative character – not as an exercise in including diversity within a predefined framework, but as a process that affirms the capacity of communities to represent themselves culturally. It is not about granting a place to what was once displaced, but about recognizing its cultural existence as a sovereign and insubordinate form.

Although in recent years UK cultural policy has sought to move beyond the “deficit model” of participation toward a broader notion of cultural democracy, in practice this discursive shift has had to be articulated within a preexisting institutional structure that limited its transformative potential. As Hadley (2018) observes, the formulation of cultural democracy did not entail a rupture with the historical commitments of British cultural policy, particularly regarding arts funding. In fact, its implementation relied heavily on an infrastructure originally designed according to the premises of the democratization of culture paradigm. This tension between the radical promise of the concept and the institutional frameworks that contain it leads, according to Hadley, to a kind of depoliticization of the term and to an omission of its critical genealogy (2018, p. 53).

Thus, although it holds profoundly transformative potential, the incorporation of the notion of cultural democracy in the British context of the twenty-first century has tended to organize its multiple implications around a central and dominant axis. To fully grasp its current scope – Hadley and Belfiore argue – it would be necessary to articulate it with “a politics of recognition attentive to class dynamics”, since the hierarchies of value that structure the cultural field are inevitably traversed by relations of power and legitimation (2018, p. 222). Perhaps attentive to this politics, British cultural policy has over the past decade shifted away from the historic focus on the democratization of culture towards a cultural democracy model, outlined perhaps most clearly in Arts Council England’s (2020) *Let’s Create* strategy.

Marking a significant shift in English cultural policy, the strategy emphasizes broad access to cultural engagement and recognizes “the growing support for and celebration of everyday creativity” (ACE, 2020, p. 10). In reframing participation beyond institutionalized arts, the strategy aims to ensure that everyone can access and enjoy creativity and culture. Rooted in a more inclusive cultural democracy framework (though the term ‘cultural democracy’ is notably absent from the document’s lexicon), *Let’s Create* departs from traditional hierarchical distinctions between professional and amateur arts, acknowledging creative expression in diverse forms and communities as worthy of funding.

In policy terms, *Let’s Create* has to date operated within a broader context of devolution, social prescribing, and the “levelling up” agenda (HM Government 2022) to neutralize the historical London bias of funding, presenting creativity as a tool for wellbeing, social cohesion, and place-making. The strategy reflects wider, international trends toward cultural wellbeing and community empowerment while retaining a distinctively English focus on locality and partnership models. Indeed, by 2030, ACE wants England to be “a country in which the creativity of each of us is valued and given the chance to flourish” (ACE, 2020).

This formulation attempts to reconcile individual creative expression with access to established cultural forms, embodying the persistent tension between democratic participation and cultural excellence that has characterized cultural policy debates since the 1970s. In contrast to the largely metropolitan development of the Global North, other regions of the world have

followed their own trajectories toward cultural democracy, shaped by particular historical, social, and institutional conditions. These paths cannot be understood as mere peripheral adaptations of central models, but rather as autonomous processes that have generated distinctive conceptual and practical frameworks.

The Latin American experience is illustrative in this regard: there, cultural democracy did not emerge as a replacement for a previous paradigm, but as a field of tensions in which democratization, popular cultures, heritage, and the arts have coexisted. Moreover, structural limitations linked to inequality and institutional fragility did not prevent the region from developing innovative proposals and contributing to the global debate on the transformation of cultural policy frameworks. Thus, the paradigm of cultural democracy has taken on specific regional forms, expressed in experiences such as the *sociocultural animation* initiatives of the 1970s or, more recently, in the proliferation of projects focused on community cultural management, such as the *cultura viva comunitaria* (living community culture) movement.

Within this dynamic, discontinuous, coexisting, local agendas have maintained a – not always harmonious – dialogue with global currents. The rise of the creative industries discourse in the late 1990s, for example, had an uneven reception in Latin America: closer to a discursive strategy – the so-called “*orange economy*” – than to a structural transformation. Cultural management in Latin America did not operate as a simple adaptation of *arts management* framed by economic efficiency; rather, it unfolded within a field of political action (Quiña, 2018). Experiences such as these show that, far from reproducing metropolitan itineraries in a linear fashion, many of the regions of the Global South have promoted their own ways of articulating the relationship between culture and democracy, in which citizen participation, political action, and the defense of diversity acquire a decisive prominence.

A central axis around which the notion of cultural democracy has been articulated is, without doubt, participation. Initially conceived as a mechanism for opening institutions toward their publics, participation has entailed recognizing individuals not as mere passive recipients of cultural goods but as active agents in the production of meaning and in the definition of cultural agendas. This “*participatory turn*” (Dupin-Meynard & Négrier, 2020) has had a significant impact on both the theory and practice of cultural policies, by establishing the need to create conditions that enable citizens to influence the processes of creation, mediation, and circulation of culture. In doing so, cultural democracy distances itself from vertical models based on the unilateral transmission of a canon and approaches more horizontal conceptions in which the voice of communities occupies a central place in the configuration of the commons.

However, in various contexts around the globe – and particularly in Latin America – the idea of participation has been expanded by other principles that both complicate and enrich it. Here, cultural democracy is not limited to opening channels of dialogue between the state and citizens but can also be understood in its articulation with other rights. Conceived in this way, cultural democracy seeks not only to enable spaces for participation but also to ensure that cultural diversity can be freely expressed and that the tensions and conflicts inherent to such plurality are recognized as constitutive elements of democratic life. From the experiences of institutionalizing multiculturalism to constitutional frameworks that incorporate Indigenous worldviews, these cases have shown that cultural democracy involves not only the right to participate and to sustain one’s own identities but also the right to dissent, to question, and to express divergence. In sum, it is about understanding participation as a field of ongoing negotiation among diverse and often dissonant voices.

Contemporary challenges of cultural democracy

The November 2023 sessions, along with the works gathered in this special issue and those in Peters and Hadley's (2025) recent Spanish-language collection, remind us that the challenges of cultural democracy are becoming increasingly complex and evolving alongside contemporary social transformations. Within this context, we would like to briefly highlight some of the problematic nodes that traverse these discussions – nodes that reflect both the diversity of local experiences and the transversality of the difficulties faced in implementing this paradigm across the globe.

A first debate brings us back to the question of power: today, more than ever, it is essential to once again situate the production and contestation of meaning at the heart of the concept of culture. The arts, heritage, and cultural practices are not mere spaces of symbolic representation but arenas where social projects, interests, and worldviews confront one another. Thinking about cultural democracy from this perspective entails recognizing that cultural policies not only promote access or participation but also enable – or constrain – the capacity of different actors to contest legitimate forms of meaning-making.

Secondly, it is necessary to debate decentralization. Although cultural policies have opened up to new actors – such as local governments, community organizations, and civil society – in many cases, the mechanisms designed to decentralize end up reproducing centralist logics. The experience of *Puntos de Cultura* in Latin America illustrates both the reach and the limitations of this process: while it expanded opportunities for access to resources and visibility, it also revealed the persistence of institutional frameworks that tend to reproduce preexisting schemes. This suggests that an effective cultural democracy requires not only the redistribution of funds or competences but also the radical opening of spaces for political and cultural decision-making.

Finally, the third axis refers to mainstreaming – or, in Víctor Vich's terms, to the need to “deculturalize culture” (2013). From this perspective, culture ceases to be conceived as an autonomous field and is instead understood as a constitutive dimension of all social practice. This implies broadening the scope of cultural policies toward areas traditionally regarded as external – such as education, health, urban planning, or the environment – while recognizing the symbolic density that permeates them. In this sense, a contemporary cultural democracy is not limited to ensuring participation in the artistic sphere but seeks to guarantee that historically excluded identities can represent themselves and contest meanings in all domains of public life.

Yet cultural democracy remains an unstable horizon, whose effective materialization is often more perceptible in theory than in practice. For this reason, it is necessary to pose some uncomfortable questions: is cultural democracy more an expression of ideological desire than a basis upon which to develop normative policy? A well-intentioned formulation that fails to consolidate as a concrete project? What viability does it have in a regional context marked by the advance of authoritarian projects, where processes of cultural decentering – far from consolidating – are increasingly under threat? To ask these questions does not mean abandoning the paradigm but rather strengthening its political character. Cultural democracy, situated within a global dialogue, entails recognizing its structural fragility but also its critical power as a tool for confronting the limits of the present and for experimenting, from our own coordinates, with fairer forms of shared cultural life.

Future projections of cultural democracy

Concepts have a history and, at the same time, they contribute to writing history. The fact that this special issue of *Cultural Trends* seeks to re-situate cultural democracy as a contemporary problem revitalizes the debate on the future of cultural policies. In times when democracy is rapidly weakening, military conflicts persist, and social discontent grows, the future becomes unpredictable. As we witness both genocide in Gaza and genocide-denial across a swathe of European governments, high uncertainty and growing distrust become the norm. Yet the future experiences phases of contraction and expansion; that is, the construction of positive or negative expectations about the future varies according to historical contexts. By contributing to the creation of new lines of flight for the cultural policies of tomorrow, cultural democracy has much to say – and to do – in this scenario.

Perhaps some of its most important components remain present in the current spirit of international organizations dedicated to promoting cultural policies. At the end of September 2025, the Third World Conference on Cultural Policies and Sustainable Development – known since 1982 as *Mondiacult* – was held in Barcelona. This event brought together not only ministers and cultural authorities from UNESCO member states but also a range of civil society actors – such as *Laboratorio Nómada*, *Ágora Cívica*, *Cultura y Ciudadanía*, *Ameroibérica*, and *Culturópolis* – who organized parallel activities aimed at reflecting on the future challenges of cultural policies within today's complex global landscape. Despite the power asymmetry between institutional actors and social agents, safeguarding the role of culture in contemporary society was a shared concern. Taken as a whole, the conference called for reinforcing culture both as a human right and as a key factor for fostering global peace.

As in the first *Mondiacult* declaration of 1982 – where one of the most widely used global definitions of the term “culture” was proposed – the foundational ideas of cultural democracy were not absent. As stated in the “*Barcelona Declaration*”, UNESCO Member States made “a collective commitment to firmly anchor culture as a component and pillar of just, peaceful, and sustainable development – not only as a human right for every person to participate in cultural life, but also as a global public good”. Along with pledging to support cultural policies and the cultural and creative sectors as a whole, the declaration also called for reinforcing the idea that “culture contributes to the well-being of all people, to cultural diversity and cultural expressions, to the preservation of knowledge and heritage, and to the shared care of our planet”.

In sum, this new declaration moved away from certain economistic approaches within UNESCO that had emphasized the notion of “culture as a public good”, toward a vision closer to the idea of cultural democracy that is emphasized throughout this special issue: one that recognizes the right of all people not only to access, but also to create, participate in, interpret and make decisions about cultural life.

This new declaration entails protecting and fostering communities' own forms of symbolic production by promoting more horizontal decision-making structures. In this sense, it is a profoundly political declaration – one that connects to debates on cultural justice, citizenship, and democratic participation – and that also seeks to reflect on the potential effects of artificial intelligence on contemporary culture. Taken together, all these debates are expected to provide the argumentative foundations for integrating culture into the post-2030 United Nations (UN) sustainable development framework, this time as an “independent goal” in its own right. Within this scenario, we hope that the studies and reflections included in this special issue will contribute to developing this new future agenda for global cultural policy.

Each of the articles gathered here offers a significant contribution to the debates on cultural democracy and its future. We wish to thank all the authors for their trust in this project and, of course, *Cultural Trends* for making this special issue possible. We hope that this volume helps

to reaffirm the importance of cultural democracy within contemporary cultural policy through a truly global dialogue.

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